Translation Drafting Steps: Training Guide

Training Goals:

1. The audience will understand that:
   - ☐ The Eight Steps of Church-Owned Bible Translation produce a meaning-based translation.
   - ☐ The four drafting steps produce a draft that sounds natural in the target language.
   - ☐ The steps must be done in sequence and within the allotted time.
2. The audience will try the four drafting steps (Exercise).

Estimated Time: *60-90 min.*

Materials:
- ✓ *Slides: Translation Drafting Steps - Slides (Optional)*
- ✓ ***Eight Steps for Workshops*** *(1 copy for each person)*
- ✓ ***Luke 17:11-19 ULB*** *or another passage (1 copy for each person)*
- ✓ *White board and markers (Optional)*
- ✓ *Eight Steps Bookmarks (Optional; this is a separate document)*

Introduction: The Eight-Step translation process is designed to create meaning-based translations. The process focuses the translator on meaningful, natural wording first, then applies careful checking to assure accuracy and completeness.



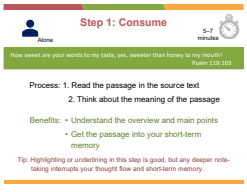
Three key qualities of a good translation are **naturalness, accuracy,** and **clarity**. The translation process Wycliffe Associates uses helps to ensure these three qualities through three processes: **drafting, checking,** and **community review**.



The first four steps, the drafting steps, enable the translator to express the meaning in a way that is **natural** in the target language. If translators do not focus on naturalness first, it is hard or impossible to make the draft sound natural later. The next four steps are checking steps, which help the translator ensure that the draft is **accurate**. After these Eight Steps, the translator will have produced a good, working draft. The term "Eight Steps" refers to the process of creating this working draft. Then, the translation team and their church community will review the translation as a whole, making sure it is not only natural and accurate, but also **clear** in the way it communicates the message of the original text.

The first four steps are drafting steps. TIMING is very important in these steps.

Step 1: *Consume*—(Alone) Read and understand the whole portion of text.



Each translator will privately read their passage of Scripture in the source language. They should try to understand both the meaning and main points of the text to get a general overview of the passage. This step should take no more than 5–7 minutes.

Note: If the passage is longer and needs more time, translators should complete the four drafting steps with the portion they were able to consume in 7 minutes, and save the rest of the passage for another drafting session.

Share Psalm 119:103 with the group.

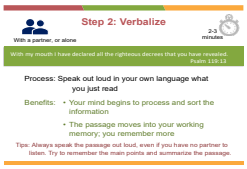
If translators struggle to understand something in the passage, it is also OK to pause and seek clarification from resources or other team members. Then the translator should begin consuming the passage again at the beginning and restart the time. Please note that translators may only use resources or discuss with

other team members **if they take a break** from the drafting process; **they should look at their open-licensed source text only and not use any resources during their timed drafting steps.**

Helpful tips: Some people naturally prefer to highlight or underline while they read, and this is a great way for some translators to consume the text. However, everyone is different. All translators should avoid any study method that distracts them from the overall meaning of the passage

Trainers should be aware that avoiding resources during the four drafting steps is necessary to prevent distractions that interrupt the brain's natural learning processes. (This will be discussed in "Why the Eight Steps Work.") However, this can also be important for legal reasons. If translators look at any resources during Steps 1-4, these resources are all considered "sources" for the translation. If any of those resources are not open-licensed, the draft will be the property of the copyright holders of those resources, rather than the target-language believers.

Step 2: *Verbalize*—(With a partner) Tell out loud what the passage is about.



In the target language, the translator will tell out loud what the passage was about. Even if a partner is not available, translators should verbalize the meaning of the passage out loud to themselves.

Share Psalm 119:13 with the group.

Translators should think about:

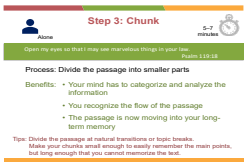
- What are the big ideas?
- What events are in the passage?
- Who are the people in the passage and what did they do?

Note: To preserve the brain's natural memory ability, each translator should go through the first four steps without interruption. This means that if translators are taking turns verbalizing to each another, one translator should go straight through all four steps first (verbalizing to a second translator during Step 2). Then, the second translator can go through all four steps consecutively after the first translator is finished drafting their Blind Draft.

The purpose of this step is to express the passage out loud to help the translator remember and understand what it is about. This step is where meaning, naturalness, and flow begin to form in the translator's mind. This should take about 2–3 minutes.

Helpful tip: Translators should think of this as a summary of the passage, rather than re-telling every detail. They should also avoid explaining or interpreting the passage.

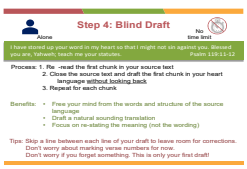
Step 3: *Chunk*—(Alone) Divide the passage into smaller sections.



The translator will look at the passage of Scripture and break it into smaller parts (complete thoughts) that they can remember and quickly rewrite. A chunk will usually be about 1–4 verses, but they should push for the maximum amount of text that they can remember yet not memorize. This step should take about 5-7 minutes.

Share Psalm 119:18 with the group.

Step 4: *Blind Draft*—(Alone) Re-read, then draft each chunk from memory.



The translator will look over the first chunk in the passage. Then, they will hide the source text from view, and write that chunk in their mother-tongue without looking back at the source text. The translator

Share Psalm 119:11-12 with the group.

will read and then blind draft each chunk, one at a time, until all the chunks of Scripture in that passage are written.

Translators should resist the temptation to look back at the source text, even if they can't remember something. The goal is to **express the meaning in natural language**. The Blind Draft will not be perfect, and that is ok! This is the first draft—it will be checked and refined.

Helpful tips: It is very helpful when translators leave a blank line between each line of their draft. This leaves space for notes and corrections later, when the team checks the draft. Translators should also not worry about writing verse numbers during this step. They should focus completely on re-telling the meaning of the passage in a natural way.

💭 **Ask: What do you think will happen if you skip any of these steps?**
Potential consequences when skipping steps include:

- Without **Consume—**Flow and connectors are lost
- Without **Verbalize—**No input/output benefits; this is a building element of chunking; skipping this will also result in "cheating" (looking at text during Blind Draft)
- Without **Chunk—**Translating too small sections; this leads to lost connectors; story is lost
- Without **Blind Draft—**Naturalness is lost; sounds choppy; too many borrowed words

Note: Be ready to give examples. Help the team understand that **skipping steps will result in more work!**

Exercise: Four Drafting Steps
Hand out *Eight Steps for Workshops* and have everyone access an open-licensed version of Luke 17:11-19 (this passage from the English ULB is included in the handouts).
Note: Do not have the translators translate different passages for the practice session. If the team wishes to start with the book they will be translating, they should all translate the same passage in order to have quality group feedback. **They will use their drafts from this session in later sessions.**



1. Have the team practice the four drafting steps with a passage of Scripture. Provide reminders when needed to follow the steps in order and not to go over the set time for each step.
2. As a homework assignment, have the team translate "Eight Steps for Workshops."

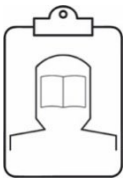
💭 **Ask:**

- **Did you follow the first four steps carefully? How do you feel about your draft?**
- **What steps of the process did you wrestle with most? Why?**
- **Are you eager to check your work and improve it?**



Confirm:
1. The audience understands that:
   □ The Eight Steps of COBT produce a meaning-based translation.
   □ The four drafting steps produce a draft that sounds natural in the target language.
   □ The steps must be done in sequence and within the allotted time.
2. The audience has tried the four drafting steps (Exercise).

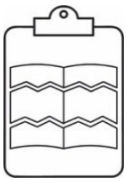
Eight Steps for Workshops



Step 1: Consume – Read your entire chapter. Try to understand the meaning and the main points of the chapter.



Step 2: Verbalize – In your mother tongue, say aloud what the chapter communicates. Focus on understanding and key points, people, places, and things.



Step 3: Chunk – Break the chapter into smaller pieces. These pieces should be complete thoughts and will generally be 1–4 verses.



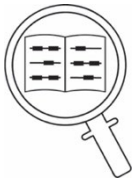
Step 4: Blind Draft – Read a chunk, turn your source text over, then write what you remember from your chunk. Complete as much as you can remember from the chunk without looking at anything. Don't worry: if you miss anything, you will have the chance to add it in the checking steps. Repeat with each chunk until you finish the chapter.



Step 5: Self-Edit – Make sure you have both your draft and the source text in front of you. Compare the draft to the source text. Look for any errors. Check for correct spelling, punctuation, and missing or added content. Correct your draft. Use resources in this step.



Step 6: Peer-Check – Share your translation with a partner. Ask the partner to look for mistakes or points of confusion, or any place where the wording does not sound natural. Work through corrections together. Use resources in this step.



Step 7: Key Word Check – For this step, make a key word list for this passage of Scripture. Work with a partner to check that every key word is represented in the text. If something is missing, work together to correct it. If there are more than a few words missing, go back to Self-Edit. If most words are there, ask for definitions of each word to make sure they are the appropriate words. Use resources in this step.



Step 8: Verse-by-Verse Check – Get two partners to be your checkers. Read your translation aloud to them one verse at a time. The first checker will translate each verse aloud back into the source language, while the second checker looks at the source text and listens to make sure that the translation is accurate and complete. Work together to give a final check to everything, making sure it is all correct. Use resources in this step.

You should try to involve many different group members at different steps, so that many translators are adding suggestions to improve the quality of the translation—as well as to make any appropriate changes. If you are not satisfied at any point, pray about it and ask God for guidance, and then ask others for input. Some things may not be resolved within one sitting or even one event and may require further help from others for improvement.

[11] It came about that as he traveled to Jerusalem, he went along the border between Samaria and Galilee.
[12] As he entered into a certain village, there he was met by ten men who were lepers. They stood far away from him [13] and they lifted up their voices, saying, "Jesus, Master, have mercy on us."

[14] When he saw them, he said to them, "Go and show yourselves to the priests." As they went away they were cleansed. [15] When one of them saw that he was healed, he turned back, with a loud voice glorifying God. [16] He fell on his face at Jesus' feet, giving him thanks. Now he was a Samaritan. [17] Then Jesus said, "Were not the ten cleansed? Where are the nine? [18] Were there no others who returned to give glory to God, except this foreigner?" [19] He said to him, "Arise, and go. Your faith has made you well."

Book Difficulty Levels

How should teams choose what to translate? First, trainers and leaders should consider whether translation has already begun in this language, or whether there is content in a similar language that they have been given permission to revise. For a training workshop, trainers often choose an easier book so that new translators will be encouraged by their progress. They may choose a book that is shorter, so the team can finish the entire draft quickly. They may choose a book that is not difficult, so the team can focus on learning the Eight Steps process without facing complex decisions about the translation.

After training, the leadership team will choose when (in what sequence) to translate each book. They should consider:

- What does the church community want to be translated?
- How experienced is the translation team?
- How much Biblical content has been translated into this language?

After noting which books have no previous usable work and must be translated from the very beginning, they should consider each book's difficulty level.

Remember, translation is a skill that grows with experience.

Because translation is a skill that grows, it is wise to start translating content that is less complicated so that the translators can learn the skill while translating something simple.

Usually, books that have more abstract, poetic, and theologically loaded terms and ideas are more difficult to translate. Books that are more narrative and concrete are generally easier to translate. Here is a chart of suggested book difficulty levels. Level 1 is the simplest, and level 4 is the most difficult.

	(chs.)	**Level 1**	(chs.)	**Level 2**	(chs.)	**Level 3**	(chs.)	**Level 4**
New Testament	24	Luke	28	Matthew	21	John	16	Romans
	28	Acts	16	Mark	16	1 Corinthians	6	Galatians
	1	Philemon	6	1 Timothy	13	2 Corinthians	6	Ephesians
			4	2 Timothy	5	1 Thessalonians	4	Colossians
			3	Titus	3	2 Thessalonians	13	Hebrews
			5	James	1	Jude	5	1 Peter
			1	2 John	4	Philippians	3	2 Peter
			1	3 John			5	1 John
			22	Revelation				
	(chs.)	**Level 1**	(chs.)	**Level 2**	(chs.)	**Level 3**	(chs.)	**Level 4**
Old Testament	24	Joshua	50	Genesis	27	Leviticus	42	Job
	21	Judges	40	Exodus	31	Proverbs	150	Psalms
	4	Ruth	36	Numbers	12	Ecclesiastes	66	Isaiah
	31	1 Samuel	34	Deuteronomy	8	Song of Songs	52	Jeremiah
	24	2 Samuel			5	Lamentations	48	Ezekiel
	22	1 Kings			12	Daniel		
	25	2 Kings			14	Hosea		
	29	1 Chronicles			3	Joel		
	36	2 Chronicles			9	Amos		
	10	Ezra			1	Obadiah		
	13	Nehemiah			7	Micah		
	10	Esther			3	Nahum		
	4	Jonah			3	Habakkuk		
					3	Zephaniah		
					2	Haggai		
					14	Zechariah		
					4	Malachi		